Karl Otfried Müller — Die Etrusker (1828; rev. Deecke, 1877)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This edition is dedicated to Karl Otfried Müller (1797–1840), the prodigy of classical studies at Göttingen, who died of fever at Athens at forty-three while travelling in Greece. His planned histories of Greek tribes and cities were left two-thirds done, and that early death is part of the measure of what he had already achieved. Before it, in 1828, he had published *Die Etrusker*, his treatise in four books on Etruscan antiquities, which this dossier credits with founding scientific Etruscology, the disciplined study of Etruscan civilisation. Wilhelm Deecke's revised edition of 1877 became the standard form, and the work is remembered here in that lasting form.

The story

Karl Otfried Müller (1797–1840) was, in the record's word, the prodigy of classical studies at Göttingen. He died of fever at Athens at forty-three, while travelling in Greece. His planned *Geschichten hellenischer Stämme und Städte* — histories of Greek tribes and cities — was left two-thirds done.

Before that early death, Müller had written the book at the centre of this dossier. *Die Etrusker*, published at Breslau in 1828, is a treatise in four books on Etruscan antiquities: the remains, customs, and history of the Etruscans, the people of

ancient Etruria in Italy. The dossier credits this treatise with founding scientific Etruscology, the disciplined study of Etruscan civilisation. Wilhelm Deecke later revised it, and Deecke's revised edition, published at Stuttgart in 1877, is the standard form.

The story of this dossier is also a story of a mistaken starting point corrected by checking. The first candidate considered was Müller's *Prolegomena zu einer wissenschaftlichen Mythologie*, published in 1825. That work is not a gap. John Leitch translated it as *Introduction to a Scientific System of Mythology*, published in London in 1844, and the translation is available in full view through HathiTrust and the Internet Archive. Other Müller works are in English as well. *Die Etrusker* is the real gap, and it was found only because the more obvious candidate was checked and set aside.

The work and what survives

Die Etrusker survives in its German editions: the 1828 original and Wilhelm Deecke's 1877 revision. In most printings it runs to two volumes. A decision is still needed, when a translation is prepared, on which text should stand as the copy-text — the 1828 original, or Deecke's 1877 revision. The recommendation in this research is Deecke's revision, disclosed on the title page, with variants from 1828 noted. That recommendation is not presented here as a decision already taken; the ruling is needed at the time the work is prepared.

The seed correction belongs in full, because it bounds what can honestly be said. Müller's *Prolegomena* was translated by Leitch in 1844. The *Dorier* was translated by Tufnell and Lewis in 1830, and the *Handbuch der Archäologie der Kunst* was translated by Leitch in 1847/50. Those works are in English. His *Orchomenos*, published in 1820, also returned no English in this pass. That result is flagged for a WorldCat hardening check — a further check of the WorldCat catalogue record — before any wording based on it is used.

Its English fortunes

No English translation of *Die Etrusker* found after research.

Searches returned only the German editions, the 1828 original and Deecke's 1877 revision, listed as German-language public-domain reproductions. That result is deliberately narrower than a claim about all of Müller's work, much of which, as the correction above shows, did reach English during the nineteenth century.

What completing it would take

Completing it would take a translation from the German, beginning with the copy-text ruling described above: 1828, or Deecke's 1877 revision, with the recommendation in this research being Deecke, disclosed on the title page and with 1828 variants noted.

The review stage would need an Etruscologist or classical archaeologist, together with a German reader. That combination reflects the work itself: a study of Etruscan antiquities, written in German, whose revised form has been the standard one since 1877.

Sources

- https://catalog.hathitrust.org/Record/011538827 (Leitch's 1844 Prolegomena translation — the correction's proof)
- https://archive.org/stream/introductiontoa01mlgoog/introductiontoa01mlgoog_djvu.txt (same, full text)
- https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/1911_Encyclop%C3%A6dia_Britannica/M%C3%BCller,_Karl_Otfried (life, death at Athens, the works)
- https://www.libreriauniversitaria.it/die-etrusker-bd-einleitung-bruchstucke/book/9781247807119 (Die Etrusker German reprint record)